



Hayward Museum. There's nothing in terms of infrastructure, training or funds," she says.

Curating is an art or skill which is mostly self-taught in India and apart from a handful of independent curators and art historians, it has largely been an open field. "It is common to have a whole team of professionally trained curators attached to every museum and gallery abroad, a trend that doesn't seem to exist in India," says

“Most gallery owners are not trained curators and I think we shouldn't even be calling ourselves curators.



DR PREMILLA BAID
OWNER, SUMUKHA GALLERY



NEVILLE TULI
CHAIRMAN, OSIAN'S

The artist-curator-administrator-teacher-promoter continuum needs to deeply expand in India.



ALKA PANDE
CURATOR

It's wonderful that artists are turning curators because they understand the aesthetics better.

KRISHNAMACHARI BOSE (TOP LEFT) IS THE ONLY INDIAN ARTIST TO HAVE SERIOUSLY MADE A DIFFERENCE TO THE CURATORIAL PROCESS IN INDIA

Amanda Miller, who recently curated a show in Bangalore.

The usual practice for gallery owners in India has been to double up as curators and put together shows that fulfil commercial rather than artistic needs. It is not surprising, therefore, to find that most shows do not credit the curator of the show, possibly because there was none. As for new-age artists curating shows, Pande says historical perspective and cultural

context is of utmost importance. "I think Bose is a wizard, but I am sorry to say I have not been impressed by shows curated by any other artist." On the other hand, Dr Premilla Baid of Sumukha Gallery believes the term 'curator' is often misused in India. "Most gallery owners are not trained curators and I think we shouldn't even be calling ourselves curators," she says.

While the quality and quantity of art produced in India has garnered worldwide attention, there has been a failure to develop ancillary institutions like museums and art colleges. Which is why Dr Storr stresses that "artists with sound knowledge and skills must become part of the curatorial process in the country". Clearly, there's a difference of opinion even among artists on whether they make for good curators and if they should be curating at all. Neville Tuli of Osian's, an art auction house, thinks it's important for the artist to become curator at times. He says, "It places them in a position of a different detachment, a different relationship with history, the creativity of others. Artists should also take on an administrative and educational responsibility of sharing ideas with the public, which are about self-expression. The artist-curator-administrator-teacher-promoter continuum needs to deeply expand in India."

Curating has merited little attention in Indian institutions. The India Foundation for the Arts headed by Anmol Vellani has recently made a move in this direction. "Our project is an endeavour to create a programme in curating for museums and galleries, with reputed professionals as faculty. It's something we are keen on," says Vellani. Bose thinks the need is rather urgent. "We have not understood the gravity of curation as a practice. It is a means of affecting the world in a powerful, personal and individual way." In a country where the word 'curator' is still a misnomer, new-age artists are filling the gap. But with many other experts of the view that curating is an exact art and only for trained professionals, the jury is yet to pronounce its judgement. ■